VON ZAROVICH ESTATE / STATION 2

The Alchemist’s Laboratory

Something sweet. Something sulfurous.

Warm air rolls out of the laboratory, carrying the smell of burnt sugar, old candle wax, and something that probably should not be bubbling. Glass tubes twist through the shadows like transparent roots. Somewhere behind a cupboard, a tiny drip keeps time.

Ten amber bottles stand in a brass rack, numbered one through ten. Each has the same dark contents and a black wax seal. In the wavering lamplight, they look exactly alike. No helpful label says what is inside.

A two-pan brass balance occupies the workbench. Its beam hangs beneath the spread wings of a grinning metal bat. Both pans are empty. Nearby, a writing desk disappears beneath papers and ink stains, while dusty ingredient jars crowd a crooked shelf.

In front of the sealed iron exit, a stone jester holds out a shallow brass bowl. Its cap curls into horns; its carved grin is much too wide. The bowl is empty. The jester looks delighted about that.

A green bubble rises in a distant flask and bursts with a rude little pop. The silence afterward feels expectant.

What do you do? Talk with your partner. Tell the DM what you want to examine or try. Your character sheet may give you ideas.

Scale half 1/2 - print 100%. Trim white margins; tape halves together at centre.

Scale half 2/2 - print 100%. Trim white margins; tape halves together at centre.

Ten Numbered Vials

Cut on the white gutters. Keep backs blank and identical. Each card is approximately 0.8 x 1.33 inches.

Place cards inside the matching pan when making a weighing. Five cards fit side by side across the centre of each assembled pan. Keep the numbers visible.

OFF THE SCALE

Put bottles that are on neither pan here.

Weighing Log

Write the vial numbers on each pan, then record the DM's result. Use a pencil.

#	LEFT PAN	RIGHT PAN	RESULT
1			
2			
3			
4			The scale creaks.
5			The bat shrieks.
6			The bat shrieks.
7			The bat shrieks.

SCALE RESULT - move the marker after each weighing.

LEFT RISES	LEVEL	RIGHT RISES

MARKER

Cut out the marker and place it on LEVEL before play. Keep this result strip beside the scale.

Rows 5 onward remain usable; a side effect does not stop the scale.

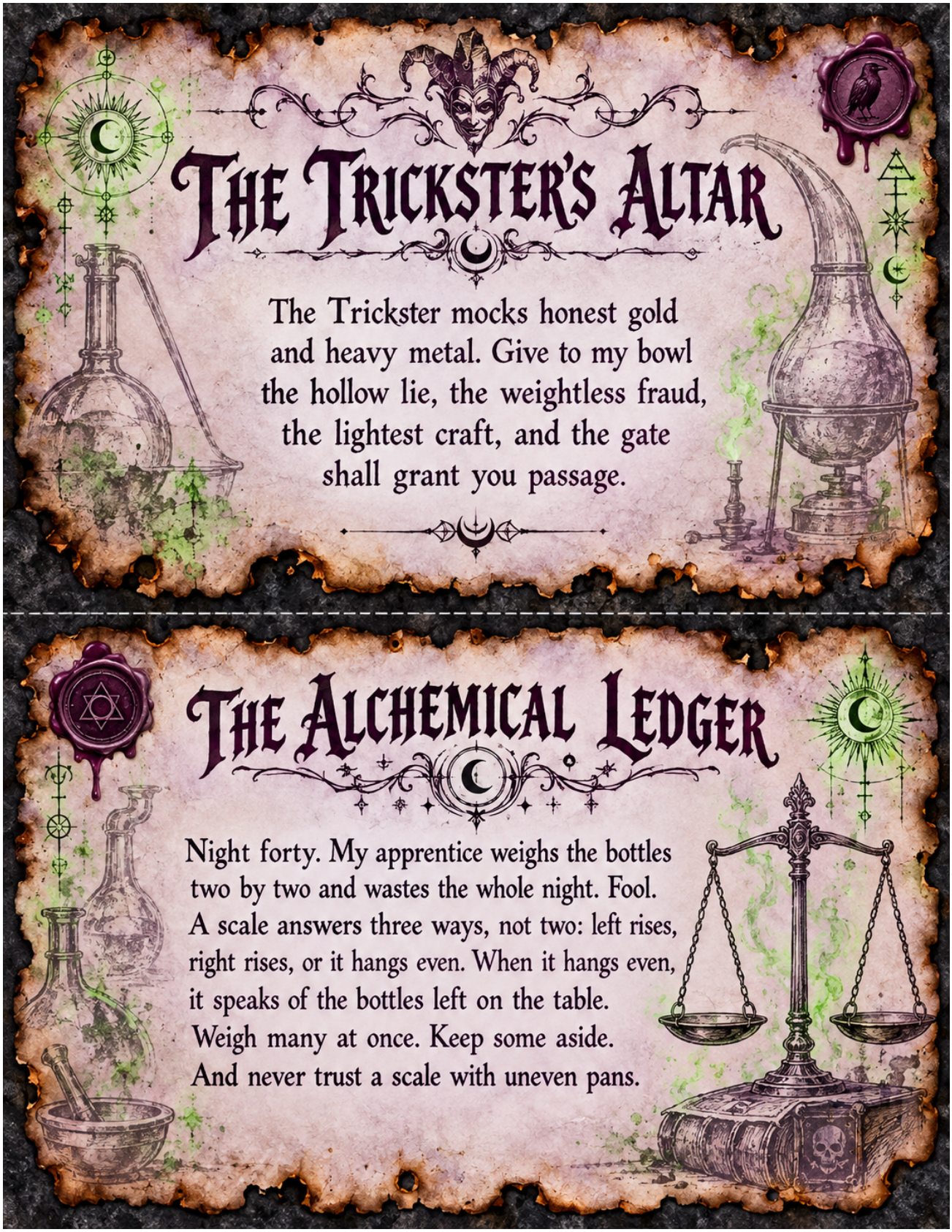
The Jester's Altar

Cut out the figure; mount in a standee clip or tape it to a folded cardstock base.

Starting prop - the altar inscription is held separately by the DM.

DM-held Clues - Envelopes 1 and 3

Cut the two parchment cards apart at their centre line. Keep the ledger hidden until its trigger.



Top: Envelope 1, altar inscription. Bottom: Envelope 3, ledger.

Side-effect Cards - DM-held

Cut the six cards apart. Hand over only the rolled card; effects end after 5 minutes or at station end.

1. Bubble Burps
Pink bubbles escape whenever you speak.

2. Helium Voice
Speak in a squeaky helium voice.

3. Radioactive Glow
You glow! Disadvantage on Stealth.

4. Sneezing Fit
An uncontrollable fit of sneezes.

5. Heavy Boots
Speed reduced by 2 squares.

6. Tingling Fingers
Move cards using two fingers of each hand.

No damage. Roll d6 for wrong offerings, taste-testing, or the fifth and later weighing.

Reward - Envelope 5

Cut out the 3-inch crest. Add Evidence E2 from the helper pack to the same envelope.

Give the crest and E2 together on completion. The players carry both to the Grand Gate.

DM-held reward - do not put it on the starting table.

STATION 2 HELPER GM — THE ALCHEMIST'S LAB (TRICKSTER'S COIN)

Pair: Quasimodo (Artificer) & Shaggy Rogers (Rogue) · **Goal:** find the one **lighter** counterfeit vial among 10 using the balance scale and offer it to the jester's bowl → **Crest #2 + Evidence Card E2**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_2_Alchemist_Lab_Tricksters_Coin.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Ten **identical** vial cards in the rack, in order 1–10. Scale mat with the tilt card on **LEVEL**. Jester altar standee.
- Weighing Log and a pencil on the table. Side-effect cards (d6) in your hand. Envelope 3 (the ledger) "in the desk drawer".
- **Pick a mode with the lead GM:** □ **Fixed:** vial **#6** is the fake (simplest) · □ **Trickster's Shuffle:** keep the Suspect Tracker (boxes 1–10) on your clipboard.

Your special job: running the scale

Players put vial cards on the LEFT and RIGHT pans and say "weigh." Answer with **exactly one** of these, every time, and move the tilt card:

> "The LEFT pan rises." · "The RIGHT pan rises." · "The pans hang perfectly level."

- **Uneven counts** (e.g. 3 vs 2): the pan with **more** vials drops, so the other pan rises. This tells them nothing.
- **Even counts:** the pan holding the fake **rises**. If the fake is on neither pan → **level**.
- Always say which pan **rises**. Never switch to "drops" partway through.
- **Shuffle mode:** before answering, split the current suspects into *left / right / off the scale*. The fake hides in the **biggest** group. Announce the result that fits, then cross off everyone else.
- **Weighing cap:** 4 free weighings. On the 4th the scale **creaks**. On the 5th and later the bat **shrieks** and whoever weighed rolls a side effect. It never becomes unwinnable.

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Read the Player Introduction aloud. Start the timer.
2:00–3:00	**Envelope 1** when they inspect the altar. Lore: Religion DC 10 (Quasimodo d20+4, Shaggy d20+0).
4:00–6:00	**Envelope 2** when Quasimodo sends Esmeralda. Prompt if needed: *"Quasimodo, your rat's whiskers are twitching at the rack."*
8:00–9:00	Point them at the desk: **Envelope 3** (Investigation DC 10; on a fail they still find it after a minute).
11:00	Still stuck, or after a wrong offering with a frustrated table: **Envelope 4**.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Finish fast, then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

Answer key (Fixed mode, fake = #6)

- 10 vials: W1 {1–5} v {6–10} → RIGHT rises · W2 {6,7} v {8,9} (10 aside) → LEFT rises · W3 6 v 7 → LEFT rises → **#6**.
- 9 vials (Esmeralda cleared #1): W1 {2,3,4} v {5,6,7} → RIGHT rises · W2 5 v 6 (7 aside) → RIGHT rises → **#6**.

STATION 2 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Failure rules (no damage anywhere in this room)

- **Wrong vial offered to the bowl:** angry sizzle, colourful smoke, the jester spits it back (it's now **cleared**). The person who offered it rolls d6:

d6	Side effect (lasts 5 min or until the station ends)
1	Bubble Burps: pink bubbles every time they speak
2	Helium Voice
3	Radioactive Glow (disadvantage on Stealth)
4	Sneezing Fit
5	Heavy Boots (speed −2 squares)
6	Tingling Fingers (move cards with two fingers of each hand)

Quick rulings

- **"I drink it!"** The wax seals are enchanted. Only a drop gets through: roll a side effect, no damage. The vial stays full. Not a critical mistake.
- **Hefting vials by hand:** *"They feel exactly the same."* No roll.
- **One vial against an empty pan:** the loaded pan drops. It counts as a weighing.
- **Several vials in the bowl:** spat back out. *"One offering."*
- **Clever ideas** (a homemade second scale, floating vials in water): count it as **one free weighing** and answer with the same rules.

Nudges (questions only)

When	Say
Wandering	*"The jester's bowl looks like it's waiting for something."*
Weighing 1 vs 1	*"Does the scale only take one bottle per pan?"*
After LEVEL: "that told us nothing!"	*"Did it tell you nothing, or something about the bottles left on the table?"*
Going in circles	*"Which vials can you be sure are real right now?"*
About to guess	*"Do you have a weighing left? Is guessing worth the risk?"*

Character rulings

- **Quasimodo, "Esmeralda the Rat":** clears **one** genuine vial (#1, or the lowest-numbered suspect in Shuffle mode). Use only while 3 or more suspects remain. With 2 left she just squeaks and shrugs. She can never find the fake.
- **Shaggy, "Iron Stomach":** no harm from tasting. May spend a use to end his own side effect early. Powers Envelope 4.

Don't

- Don't say a vial number as a hint, or look at the fake.
- Don't say "use 3 weighings" or "split into fives." That *is* the puzzle.
- Don't call a level result useless. Don't let a skill roll replace the scale.

Reward (Envelope 5)

Hand over **Crest #2** and **Evidence Card E2**: *"Take these to the Grand Gate!"*

STATION 2 — ENVELOPE LABELS

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 2 · Lab. Open when they inspect the altar (**2–3 min**).

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 2 · Lab. Open when Quasimodo uses **Esmeralda** (4–6 min).

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 2 · Lab. "In the desk drawer": open on a desk search (**8–9 min**).

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 2 · Lab. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a wrong offering.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 2 · Lab. Open on solve: **Crest #2 + Evidence Card E2**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS

ENVELOPE 1 · THE ALTAR INSCRIPTION

Hand this to the players.

> "The Trickster mocks honest gold and heavy metal. Give to my bowl the hollow lie, the weightless fraud, the lightest craft, and the gate shall grant you passage."

Religion DC 10 (read aloud on success): *"This is an altar of the Smiling Shadow, god of forgers and frauds. It accepts only the false thing, never the true one."*

ENVELOPE 2 · ESMERALDA'S NOSE (READ ALOUD)

> Esmeralda scurries along the rack, whiskers twitching. At Vial #1 she rears back and sneezes: a hairline crack in the black wax leaks sharp quicksilver vapour. That one is the real thing. She pushes it out of line with her nose. The other seals are perfect.

Shuffle mode: swap "#1" for the lowest-numbered suspect.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE SCORCH-MARKED LEDGER

Hand this to the players.

> "Night forty. My apprentice weighs the bottles two by two and wastes the whole night. Fool. A scale answers three ways, not two: left rises, right rises, or it hangs even. When it hangs even, it speaks of the bottles left on the table. Weigh many at once. Keep some aside. And never trust a scale with uneven pans."

ENVELOPE 4 · SHAGGY'S BELCH (READ ALOUD)

> Shaggy digs a squashed triple-decker sandwich out of his pocket and wolfs it down. A second later: a concussive, echoing BURRRP. Glowing pink bubbles drift across the lab, sniff around the rack like a lost puppy, and settle, fizzing, on top of three vials.

Bubbles mark 3 current suspects, one of them the fake (both, if only 2 remain). Players still do the last weighing.

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E2: THE SINGED SLEEVE

Goes in with Crest #2.

> Under the workbench: a torn lab-coat sleeve peppered with tiny burn holes from splashed quicksilver. Whoever wore it **mixed potions every day**.

DM ONLY - Suspect Tracker

Choose a mode before play: Fixed (#6) or Trickster's Shuffle. Never show this page to players.

Shuffle procedure: only on equal-count weighings, split current suspects into LEFT / RIGHT / OFF. Keep the largest group; ties may be chosen either way. LEFT group = left rises; RIGHT group = right rises; OFF group = level. Cross off other suspects before announcing the result. Unequal counts give no suspect information.

1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10

Clear a suspect: cross off its box. Esmeralda clears the lowest-numbered suspect only while at least three remain. An offering while at least two suspects remain is rejected and that offered vial is cleared. Once one remains, it is the counterfeit.

Fixed mode: #6 is always the counterfeit. Announce scale results honestly; a level result means #6 was on neither pan.

Before sealing: place helper-only instructions in a separate sleeve. Cut the helper labels/contents apart; use the illustrated altar and ledger cards instead of duplicate text cards. Envelope 5 needs both crest and E2.

Use the helper sheet for clue timing, penalties, character hooks, and emergency coaching.